

ly, your sales team may be in touch with many people. An SFA system will enable you to gather leads through various sources and consolidate them in a single place. These leads would then be contacted and further qualified—and then converted into opportunities, and finally to an order if and when the prospective customer decides to buy.

8.3.24 SOA

Service-Oriented Architecture. Traditionally, software systems in organisations were built to meet a specific need. However, this led to a situation where a number of elements of data and business processes would overlap each other in software. The service-oriented architecture is a system architecture mechanism that essentially provides the guidelines for creating and managing business processes within the organisation. The business processes are delivered as services that are supported by the IT infrastructure. Functionality is broken down into small distinct elements or services which can be distributed over the network, can be mixed and matched together, and reused to create fresh business applications. Finally, these services are able to talk to each other by passing data from one service to another.

8.3.25 Technology Strategy

This is a broad outline that will explain in simple terms what a company wishes to do in terms of information technology and how this technology infrastructure ties in with the business plan of the organisation. Depending on the size and complexity of the organisation, the strategy may need to explore such issues as: building software versus purchasing off the shelf packages, the hardware infrastructure that should be standardised throughout the organisation, the software infrastructure that should be standardised throughout the organisation, why it makes business sense to go in for a specific technology initiative, and so on.

8.3.26 Unified Communications

The merger of multiple modes of communication into a common communication platform with the basic objective of ensuring that